THE SHE LIST
UNDER 50

THE **PROFESSIONALS**

The Change Economist

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

From building a leadership school for girls to leading macroeconomic research at Tata Group, Roopa Purushothaman has linked theoretical insight with actual social impact

ROOPA PURUSHOTHAMAN, 48
Chief Economist & Head of Policy Advocacy, Tata Group; Founder, Avasara Academy
Mumbai

Born in the US to immigrant parents from Kerala, Roopa Purushothaman's career was shaped by a question she encountered as a teenager while studying public health issues in India for a school project: why do some countries become rich while others remain poor? The question stayed with her, leading her to study economics, ethics, politics and international affairs at Yale, followed by development studies at the London School of Economics.

At just 25, Roopa gained global recognition as co-author of Goldman Sachs' influential 2003 report 'Dreaming with BRICs: The Path to 2050', which argued that Brazil, Russia, India and China could emerge as major economic powers. The experience, she says, taught her to "analyse deeply and write effectively".

After moving to India and working in investment research, Roopa realised that financial constraints deprived many talented Indian girls of leadership training. To bridge that gap, she founded Avasara Academy, a non-profit, in Pune in 2015. "Not only do we seek to develop the next generation of women leaders," says Roopa, "we also wish to create a model school that couples the best of global and Indian pedagogy." The residential secondary school now has 410 students. Its graduates have gone on to institutions such as Ashoka and Krea in India, and Mount Holyoke, Syracuse and Ithaca in the US.

Since joining the Tata Group in 2017 as chief economist and head of policy advocacy, Roopa has led macroeconomic research and policy advocacy initiatives across one of India's largest conglomerates. Now based in Mumbai, her journey, in many ways, echoes the Tata tradition of linking enterprise with social purpose. ■

—M.G. Arun

HER ADVICE

"To youngsters choosing economics as a career, focus on the question that keeps you up at night, pursue it across disciplines, and learn to write simply and well"

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**